the shockers has stayed with me. Of course, you get stick in the middle, all sorts of funny looks. They'll say, 'Fucking cheat … I can't believe you've not walked for that,' more out of habit than anything else.

What do you say when the umpire asks you whether you hit it? 'Not sure, mate.' Some might give you out for being cheeky, anyway. It's a matter of degrees of difference. If you smash it to the keeper and there are two DRS reviews left, you just walk off. If the umpire gives you a little nod, that tells you he knows what's happened, you're on your way. But if it is one you might get away with, an inside edge off the pad down the leg side, you keep schtum.

It works both ways. Bowlers and fielders appeal in an orchestrated fashion, even when they know the correct verdict is not out. That would suggest the 'spirit of cricket' is little more than a clever piece of marketing, or an optimistic form of nostalgia. There are limits, however, because I understand the principle of trying to protect the game from itself.

As a captain, for instance, I would never want my bowler to Mankad a batsman – run out the non-striker before delivering the ball. I'd call him back, warn him, and warn him again, if he persists in advancing down the wicket. The term comes from the first such dismissal in a Test match by Vinoo Mankad, an Indian who ran out Australia's Bill Brown during their 1947–48 winter tour.

That created an international incident, but, revealingly, Mankad was supported by Sir Donald Bradman. Referring to scandalized press coverage in his autobiography, he wrote: 'For the life of me, I can't understand why they questioned his sportsmanship … by backing up too far or too early, the non-striker is very obviously gaining an unfair advantage.'

The rules allow it, but, in my view, it is a low blow. That's not to say I don't appreciate the contradictions, complications and consequences. When Ravi Ashwin 'Mankaded' Jos Buttler in the IPL in March 2019 it came at a crucial juncture and enabled Ashwin's team, King's XI Punjab, to beat the Rajasthan Royals. In the bowler's unrelenting world, the move made sense, but I found it objectionable because it looked premeditated. Jos would not have been out of his crease if the bowler had made a natural movement, planting his back foot in the delivery stride. Instead, Ashwin paused, prompting the batsman to edge fractionally out of his ground.

Ashwin had form in that area, having done something similar to Sri Lankan batsman Lahiru Thirimanne after warning him in a group match in